Presentation Rules SHall CompComm

Rule	Rationale & Reference	Practical Example
1 Make your headline the conclusion, not a category label.	Audiences process meaning faster when the headline tells them what to think, not merely what the slide is about. A conclusion headline lets a time-pressed executive skim every slide and reconstruct your entire argument without reading a single bullet. The headline is your most valuable pixel. *Barbara Minto, The Pyramid Principle*	Replace "Q3 Financial Update" with "Q3 revenue beat forecast by 18%, driven entirely by enterprise upsell" - the reader knows the story before they absorb the chart below it.
2 Cap your data at three figures per slide, and narrate each one.	Cognitive load research shows that when more than three numbers compete on one surface, none registers with the audience. Selecting the three most decision-relevant figures forces editorial discipline, and writing one explanatory sentence per figure converts data into evidence. *Edward Tufte, The Visual Display of Quantitative Information*	A financial slide shows exactly three numbers: 18% revenue beat, 94% gross margin, and 2.1x pipeline coverage - each followed by a single sentence explaining what it means for the forecast, not just what it is.
3 Speak to your audience, never recite what is on screen.	When a presenter reads slide text aloud, the audience reads it simultaneously and finishes first, leaving them ahead of the speaker and disengaged. Your voice must add a layer the slide cannot carry - context, emphasis, nuance, and judgment. The slide is the outline; you are the argument. *Garr Reynolds, Presentation Zen*	The slide carries the headline "Churn accelerated in SMB" and a single line chart. The presenter says nothing on the slide - instead delivering: "We lost these customers in the six weeks immediately after the pricing change, which tells us the issue is price sensitivity, not product dissatisfaction."
4 Build every slide from exactly three elements: headline, visual, speaker.	This triad creates a self-reinforcing communication system where the headline states the claim, the visual evidences it, and the speaker explains its implications. Remove one element and the argument weakens; add a fourth - a text block, a second chart, a footnote table - and the audience must choose where to look, which means they look nowhere decisively. *Nancy Duarte, Slide:ology*	A market-entry slide carries the headline "Southeast Asia is our highest-margin expansion opportunity," a single bubble chart plotting margin against market size, and a presenter who explains the competitive moat that makes that margin defensible - nothing else on the canvas.
5 Lock your visual theme and never break it accidentally.	Inconsistency in font, colour, or layout signals that a deck was assembled from separate sources rather than authored with intention, eroding trust in the content itself before the argument is even heard. A master slide template applied to every page is not a design luxury - it is a credibility mechanism. *Duarte Design principles, Nancy Duarte*	Every slide in a board deck uses the same two-font system, the same four-colour palette, and the same header-zone layout. The only deliberate exception is a single red-background slide used to signal a critical risk - a contrast that works precisely because everything else is uniform.
6 Set body text at 24pt minimum and headlines at 36pt minimum.	Text that forces an audience to squint has already failed its job before the message registers. Large type is not a stylistic preference - it is evidence that the writer has edited to essentials, because generous type sizes are only achievable once surplus words have been removed. Small type is a symptom of too much content, not too little space. *Reynolds, Presentation Zen; general UX legibility research*	A presenter auditing their draft notices that the competitive landscape slide requires 16pt type to fit five company descriptions. The fix is not to shrink the font - it is to reduce to two competitors and add a second slide, keeping all type at 28pt throughout.
7 Treat empty space as an active design decision, not a failure to fill.	A slide packed to every margin signals that the presenter could not decide what mattered, so they included everything. White space directs the eye deliberately to the element that carries the argument, and communicates that the presenter is confident enough in their content to leave room around it. The discipline to leave space and the discipline to cut words are the same discipline. *Robin Williams, The Non-Designer's Design Book*	A strategy slide contains one 48pt headline at the top, one full-bleed photograph of a manufacturing floor in the centre, and nothing else. Fifty percent of the canvas is open space. Every eye in the room goes immediately to the image - because there is nowhere else to go.
8 Use only high-resolution, purposefully chosen images - or use none at all.	A pixelated photograph or a generic stock image does not merely fail to help - it actively signals that the presenter treated the visual as an afterthought, which transfers to how the audience perceives the content. Every image is a proxy for the presenter's standards and attention, so a bad image is always worse than a blank canvas. *Garr Reynolds, Presentation Zen*	Instead of a stock-photo handshake to illustrate a partnership announcement, the presenter uses an actual photograph of the two CEOs at the signing meeting. If no quality image exists, the slide runs without one - a clean headline and a chart only, which is stronger than a forgettable visual.
9 Deploy animation only when it directly serves comprehension, never for decoration.	Animation that reveals each stage of a process one step at a time controls the audience's attention and prevents them reading ahead of the presenter's explanation - that is a legitimate use. Animation that spins, bounces, or dissolves for visual variety consumes audience attention without rewarding it, signalling that the designer prioritised spectacle over substance. *Edward Tufte, The Cognitive Style of PowerPoint*	A five-step product development process is built so that each stage appears only when the presenter clicks to it, preventing the audience from jumping to stage five while the presenter is explaining stage two. Every other slide in the deck transitions with a simple cut - no motion, no delay.
10 Make a deliberate visual choice that reflects your perspective - safe design is forgettable design.	A deck calibrated to offend no stakeholder produces a visual identity so neutral it carries no signal about the thinking behind it. Distinctive colour choices, unexpected but logical layouts, and original visual treatments are what separate a memorable argument from a deck that could have been produced by anyone. Distinctiveness is a function of editorial courage, not aesthetic recklessness. *Scott Berkun, Confessions of a Public Speaker*	Rather than the corporate blue-and-grey default, a strategy consultant uses a high-contrast black background with white type and a single amber accent colour throughout. The choice reflects the urgency of the transformation case being made - and every client who receives the deck recalls which consultancy produced it.
11 End on a specific call to action, not a pleasantry slide.	The final slide is the last thing the audience sees during Q and A and when the room photograph circulates - spending that space on "Thank You" or "Questions?" wastes the highest-recall moment of the presentation. The closing slide should state the single most important action you want the audience to take, making it concrete, attributable, and time-bound where possible. *Carmine Gallo, Talk Like TED*	The final slide of a funding proposal reads: "Approve $2.4M Series A allocation by 14 February - contact James Okafor, james@companyname.com" in 48pt type on a clean white canvas. No logo. No "Thank You." Just the ask.
12 Build a separate document for distribution - never send your live deck as a leave-behind.	A presentation deck is engineered for a room: minimal text, large type, images that the speaker narrates. A document is engineered for a reader: sufficient prose, referenced data, self-contained logic. Sending a presentation deck to someone who was not in the room produces confusion; attaching excessive prose to a live deck produces a presentation no one can follow. These are two distinct communication products requiring two distinct designs. *Garr Reynolds, Presentation Zen; general communication design practice*	After a board presentation, the presenter sends two files: the original 12-slide visual deck for those who attended, and a separate 4-page Word summary document for board members who were absent - same argument, same data, entirely different format engineered for solo reading rather than projected delivery.